



Photographs by PURUSHOTTOM DIWAKAR

MANISH DIXIT, 38

A civil engineer convicted of murder, he drives a Scorpio, uses the latest cellphone and lives in a well-furnished house in Sanganer's open jail.

**SURAJ MAL, 32**

Convicted of murdering his sister-in-law, he is in an open jail located on the campus of the Agriculture Research Station, Jodhpur, and earns Rs 2,600 a month by working on a farm there.

**URMILA JAIN, 42**

Convicted in a case of mass suicide, she has been in Sanganer open jail for seven years now. She helps run a crèche for the children of jail inmates which earns her Rs 1,800 a month.

**SUMITRA, 48**

Once headmistress of a government school, she was convicted of killing a servant. Inmate of an open jail near Jodhpur since 2002, she works as an assistant in a laboratory.

than's director-general of police.

Another notable feature of the open jail is the presence of women living alone in the company of male prisoners. There is no segregation as in normal prisons but most women find it quite safe. Sumitra, 48, was once headmistress in a government school and was convicted of killing a servant. She has been lodged in an open jail in Jodhpur since 2002 and works as an assistant in a laboratory. "It is like living with a family," she says.

The minimum time served in regular jail to qualify convicts for open jails is six years. Thus, it is only those serving long sentences who get into open jails, usually for another six to 10 years. These prisons come under the

Rajasthan Prisoners Open Air Camp Rules under which there is no defined size or population (some new jails being proposed will begin with just 10 prisoners) and there have to be provisions for employment.

Considering the facilities and relative freedom, jail officials admit that bribes and high-level recommendations play a role in selecting inmates. Preeta Bhargav, Rajasthan's first woman superintendent of police who is also in charge of Sanganer, insists that the norm for picking convicts with exceptionally good conduct for open jails needs to be strictly followed.

Despite infringements, it does provide an ideal atmosphere for prisoners to be rehabilitated into society.

Mohan Lal, 58, worked as a cashier in a bank in Jaipur and was convicted in a dowry death case. He used his time in Sanganer to set up an iron trading business. Most open jail prisoners meet their own expenses. What is also remarkable is that very few prisoners escape, even though security is virtually non-existent in these jails.

There were just seven escapes between 1988 and 1997, which rose to 32 between 1998 and 2008. Even that is a relatively minuscule number. Further, prisoners have a deadline for returning to the campus and any infringement means they are shifted back to regular jails. Not many want to risk being deprived of the freedom and opportunities that open jails provide. ■